

OSINT 101

Investigation Plan Template

Structured investigation scoping and planning document

Open-Source Intelligence, Explained

osint101.com

1. Investigation Overview

Objective

Clearly state the primary goal of this investigation. What specific question or hypothesis are you testing? Define success criteria in measurable terms so you know when the objective has been met.

Scope

Define the boundaries of the investigation -- what is included and, equally important, what is explicitly excluded. Scope creep is one of the most common failure modes in OSINT operations.

2. Sources & Tools

#	Source / Tool	Type	Access
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			

3. Resource Allocation

Time Budget

Estimated hours: _____ | Deadline: _____

Personnel

Lead investigator: _____ | Team members: _____

4. Operational Parameters

Stop Conditions

Define conditions under which the investigation will be suspended or terminated:

- (a) Objective confirmed
- (b) Dead end reached after exhausting all listed sources
- (c) Legal/ethical boundary encountered
- (d) Client/authorization withdrawn

Legal Boundaries

List applicable jurisdictions, data protection regulations (GDPR, CCPA, etc.), terms of service constraints, and any ethics committee approvals required.

Confidence Targets

Define the minimum confidence level required for conclusions:

Low (50-60%) / Medium (60-80%) / High (80-95%) / Near-certain (>95%)

Document the evidence threshold for each tier.

5. Reporting Plan

Expected deliverable format: _____ | Audience: _____

Classification level: _____ | Distribution list: _____

Appendix A: Source Tracker

#	Source	Checked	Result
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			
13			
14			
15			

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